LAUNCH ROADMAP

Brief! - from localhost to briefmessage.net

Version 2 | Updated for Brief! 2.3.0 | Domain, hosting, new features, billing, pricing

Purpose	The steps, in order, that turn Brief! from a project that runs on one computer into a product a team can sign up for and pay for at briefmessage.net.
What changed since version 1 (October 6)	The product direction is decided. Milestone M1 is built (Brief! 2.3.0). The Cloudflare and Render steps are now screen by screen, answering your screenshots of October 8. New Section 9: attachments and the installable app. Render's plan names and limits were checked again.
Starting point	Brief! 2.3.0: 207 tests written, first real run pending; 2.2.0 verified at 149 of 149. Domain registered at Cloudflare, no DNS records yet. Nothing deployed.
How to read the numbers	Prices and plan limits were checked on the vendor's own pages on October 9, 2026, unless a line says October 6. Vendors change them. Confirm each figure on its pricing page before you act on it.
What this is not	Legal, tax or financial advice. Section 13 lists questions to settle with the right professional.

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1. Where Things Stand

You have	You do not have yet
A working application with accounts, posts, mentions, alerts, paging and an API documentation page	A deployment. It runs on your computer and your Wi-Fi only.
Security that would survive a review: hashed passwords, signed tokens, ownership rules, a login rate limit that works behind a proxy	HTTPS, which arrives with hosting
A domain: briefmessage.net, at Cloudflare	Any DNS record. Your screen shows 0 of 200 used.
New in 2.3.0: a build that runs on PostgreSQL, changes its schema through versioned migrations, and ships with a Dockerfile and a render.yaml	Its first real test run on your machine
New in 2.3.0: a web app that installs on a phone or computer and opens without a connection	Notifications that reach the app while it is closed
A repeatable test suite, set up to run on PostgreSQL in CI as well	A GitHub push of 2.3.0, which starts that CI
Experience launching PixelPerfect on the same vendors	Email on accounts: no password reset, no verification, no billing contact
One public board	Private boards. Today everyone who registers sees everything.
	Terms of service, privacy policy, pricing page, payment

Two rows moved from the right column to the left since version 1: PostgreSQL with migrations, and a build that can be deployed. The right column is still the roadmap.

2. What Is Being Sold

Decided on October 8: Brief! is a private board for small teams (direction B of version 1). A team of 3 to 30 gets one place for short updates that must be read. The 255-character limit is the feature; mentions are the reason to open it; the money is a small monthly subscription per board; a private group moderates itself.

> **Positioning (a hypothesis to test, not a fact)**
>
> **One sentence to test on real people:** "Brief! is a private board for your team where every post is 255 characters or less, so the things everyone must read do not drown in chat. It installs on your phone straight from the browser."
>
> It does not replace Slack or Teams. It sits beside them, as the place for the few messages a day that must not be missed.

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Adding "it works as an app on your phone"

Yes, add it. It is true as of 2.3.0 and it answers a question every team will ask. Say what it does, in words a listener can check:

Say this	Because, as of 2.3.0
"Installs on your phone from the browser. No app store."	Android, iPhone, iPad, Windows and Mac can add it to the home screen or desktop, where it opens in its own window.
"Opens instantly, even with no signal."	The app's own files are kept on the device. Posts still need a connection.
"Shows how many mentions are waiting."	On the tab title everywhere; on the app icon where the system supports it.
Not yet: "Notifies you the moment you are mentioned."	Today that works only while Brief! is open. Notifications to a closed app arrive with M3 (Section 9).
Avoid: "more reliable and efficient"	A listener cannot check it, so it sounds like every other product. The three lines above can be shown in ten seconds.

On building in a crowded market

You wrote that Brief! will be built whether or not similar products exist, because you are part of the market too. I agree with the decision. Other products are proof that teams pay for this kind of tool, and nobody needs permission to compete.

What I would keep from version 1 is the order of work, not the doubt. The large tools have free tiers, so the first question from any team will be "why not just use what we have?", and the sentence above has to answer it. "Brief" is a common word in software, so search the trademark database before paying for a logo. And this is a third product competing for the same hours as PixelPerfect and ContentCalendar.ai.

So the gate stays: once M2 is online, ask five real teams to use it free for two weeks. That does not decide whether to build. It decides what to build next, with evidence in place of my guesses and yours.

3. The Roadmap: Milestones

Each milestone ends in something you can check. Effort is a rough estimate for evenings beside your other work.

	Milestone	What is built or done	Done when	Status
M0	**Secure the domain**	Auto-renew confirmed, DNSSEC on, two-factor sign-in, two forwarding addresses	A message to hello@briefmessage.net reaches your inbox	**YOU** 30 minutes Section 4
M1	**A deployable build** (Brief! 2.3.0)	PostgreSQL, Flyway migrations, foreign keys, Dockerfile, render.yaml, the visitor's address behind a proxy, usernames unique whatever the capitals, paged mentions	The 207 tests pass on your machine, and the Docker image builds and answers /health	**BUILT** Your run is left Section 5
M2	**Online**	GitHub push; Render Blueprint creates the service and the database; custom domain through Cloudflare; HTTPS	https://briefmessage.net shows Brief!, and data survives a redeploy	**NEXT** 1 to 2 days Sections 6, 7
	Validation gate	*Five teams, two weeks, free.*	*You know what they used, and what they asked for*	

	Milestone	What is built or done	Done when	Status
M3	**Real accounts** (2.4)	Email on accounts, verification link, password reset, a bot check at sign-up, account deletion, Terms and Privacy pages. Push notifications for the installed app. Staying signed in for more than 12 hours	A stranger can register, forget the password and recover it; a mention reaches a closed app	**LATER** about 2 weeks
M4	**Private boards** (2.5)	Workspaces: every post belongs to one. Invitations by email. Roles: owner and member. A landing page for visitors who are not signed in	Two teams use the same server and cannot see each other's posts	**LATER** 2 to 3 weeks
M4a	**Attachments** (2.6)	Images, PDF and text files on a post; object storage; limits per plan (Section 9)	A member attaches a screenshot; only that board's members can open it	**LATER** 1 to 2 weeks
M5	**Payment**	Stripe Checkout, customer portal, webhooks; plan limits enforced; pricing page	A real card pays, the board is upgraded, and cancelling downgrades it	**LATER** 1 to 2 weeks
M6	**Launch**	Uptime monitoring, error alerts, a tested database restore, support address, DMCA agent, announcement	You would be comfortable if a customer signed up while you slept	**LATER** about a week

Why this release covers M1 and not M0 to M4

You asked whether one release could cover M0 through M3 or M4. It could be written; I advise against it, for three reasons.

- **M0 and M2 are not code.** They are done in the Cloudflare and Render dashboards, by you. Sections 4, 6 and 7 are the guide.
- **Every release is written without real Spring and first runs on your machine.** That has worked five times because each release was one step. If accounts with email, private boards and deployment arrived together and the first run failed, neither of us could say which part broke.
- **M3 and M4 need decisions that are not made yet:** which mail provider (it needs your account and DNS records), and what the five test teams ask for. Building them before M2 is online means guessing.

The working approach stays as agreed: you send the test result and screenshots, the next zip follows. One milestone per release keeps each of those rounds short.

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4. M0 Now: Cloudflare, Screen by Screen

Your two Cloudflare screenshots, answered

The DNS records page, with the arrow at "Add record". Do not add a record yet. The three recommendations on that page are correct but early. The two about visitors need the address of the Render service, which does not exist until M2; Section 7 gives the two records to add then. The one about email is solved by the next step, which adds its records by itself.

The Email Routing page, "Verify DNS records". Click **Activate**. It offers briefmessage.net and not hello@ or support@ because these records (the three MX records on your screen and the TXT records under them) belong to the whole domain: they tell the world that Cloudflare receives mail for it. The individual addresses are created right after, in step 3 below.

Yes, this is the "Receive" row of the Email section (Section 8 here, Section 7 in version 1) and part of M0.

Step	Where in the Cloudflare dashboard	Do this	You will see
1	Email Routing, the page of your screenshot	Click **Activate**.	The DNS records page now lists three MX records and TXT records, where it said 0 of 200. The "Email cannot reach" recommendation goes away.
2	Compute > Email Service > Email Routing > **Destination Addresses**	Enter the inbox the mail should arrive in. Open the message Cloudflare sends there and select **Verify email address**.	The address is shown as verified. Until then, rules that point at it stay disabled.
3	Email Routing > **Routing Rules** > Create routing rule	Email pattern: **hello**, domain briefmessage.net. Action: send to an email. Destination: the verified address. Create a second rule for **support**.	Two rules, both active.
4	Any other email account	Send a message to hello@briefmessage.net.	It arrives in your inbox. Send it from a different account than the one it forwards to: a mail provider can hide a message you send to yourself.
5	DNS > Settings > **DNSSEC**	Click **Enable DNSSEC**. For a domain registered at Cloudflare the DS record is added for you.	"Pending" at first. Becoming active can take one to two days. Nothing else to do.
6	Your profile (top right) > Authentication	Turn on **two-factor authentication**. Store the recovery codes outside the computer.	Signing in asks for a code.
7	Domain Registration > Manage Domains > briefmessage.net	Confirm **Auto-renew** is on and that the payment method will still be valid at renewal. Leave the domain locked.	Auto-renew: on.

- Email Routing only receives. Sending mail from the application (verification links, password resets) comes with M3 and a separate provider (Section 8).
- If two rules have the same pattern, only the first one in the list is used.
- Menu names are as Cloudflare's documentation gave them on October 9. If a label differs slightly on your screen, the page titles in bold are the ones to look for.

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- The 60-day rule from version 1 still holds: a newly registered domain cannot be moved to another registrar for 60 days. Nothing in this plan needs that.

5. M1: Run 2.3.0 on Your Machine

The build is written. What makes it "verified" is its first run on the real stack, which only your machine can do. About 20 minutes.

```
cd Brief_v2.3.0\brief\backend-spring
.\mvnw.cmd test                       # send back the line that starts with "Tests run:"
#   expected:  Tests run: 207, Failures: 0, Errors: 0, Skipped: 0
.\mvnw.cmd package
java -jar target\brief-spring.jar     # open http://localhost:8080
```

1. **Keeping your current members and posts?** Copy the h2 folder of 2.2.0 into the new backend-spring folder before the first start, and keep a second copy somewhere else. 2.3.0 changes that database once, and H2 cannot undo a change that fails half-way.
2. **Things to try in the running app:** sign in typing your name in other capitals; post a line containing pixelperfectapi.net and click it; open Mentions; tick "Stay signed in", close the tab, open it again. In Chrome or Edge on the computer, "Install Brief! on this device" appears under API docs.
3. **In the log,** look for `Database: H2 file ./h2/brief-spring on this machine.` A notice beginning `Flyway upgrade recommended: H2 2.2.224 is newer` is expected and harmless.
4. **Optional, with Docker Desktop:** the same tests against PostgreSQL, and the Docker image. The commands are in the README and in OTSR v5, Section 12.
5. **Push 2.3.0 to GitHub.** The CI workflow then runs five jobs, among them the suite on PostgreSQL 16 and a build and start of the Docker image. If you have no Docker on your machine, this is where the Dockerfile gets its first real test.

The phone cannot install the app from http://192.168... because browsers allow installing only over HTTPS. That part waits for M2.

6. M2: Hosting on Render

> **Your three screenshots about Render, answered**
>
> **PixelPerfect's Environment page.** It is the same kind of page that will hold Brief!'s variables, but it belongs to another service. Do not add anything of Brief! to pixelperfect-api-docker. Brief! gets its own web service and its own database, in the same workspace.
>
> **The list "Settings on the Render web service" from version 1.** You will not type those in. The file render.yaml in the 2.3.0 zip creates them. The list also became shorter; the table below shows what replaced what.
>
> **The Dockerfile sketch.** Nothing for you to implement. Version 1 said "the tested version ships with 2.3": it is the file named Dockerfile at the top of the 2.3.0 folder.

Version 1 planned	2.3.0 does	Who sets it
`PORT`, set by Render	The same	Render
`BRIEF_AUTH_MODE` = strict	The same	render.yaml

Version 1 planned	2.3.0 does	Who sets it
`BRIEF_JWT_SECRET`, generated by Render	The same: 256 random bits, made once and kept	render.yaml
`SPRING_PROFILES_ACTIVE` = postgres	**Not needed.** A PostgreSQL address alone selects PostgreSQL	-
`BRIEF_DB_URL`, `BRIEF_DB_USER`, `BRIEF_DB_PASSWORD`, built by hand from the database's host, port and name	**Replaced by one variable,** `DATABASE_URL`**.** Render fills it from the database; the application converts it to what Java needs when it starts	render.yaml
-	**New:** `BRIEF_CLIENT_IP_HEADER` = CF-Connecting-IP, so the login rate limit counts the visitor and not Render's proxy	render.yaml
Health check path /health	The same	render.yaml

The steps

1. **GitHub.** The repository's top level must be the contents of the brief folder, so that Dockerfile and render.yaml are at the top. A private repository is fine. Wait until the CI run is green.
2. **Render.** In the workspace that holds PixelPerfect: **New > Blueprint**, choose the repository. Render reads render.yaml and lists what it will create: a web service named brief and a database named brief-db. Confirm.
3. **The first build** takes several minutes, because Maven downloads its libraries inside the build. In the service's Logs, wait for `Database: PostgreSQL, //dpg-...` and `Started BriefApplication`.
4. **Try it** at the onrender.com address Render shows: create an account, post, open /health and /docs/index.html.
5. **Redeploy once on purpose** (Manual Deploy > Deploy latest commit). The account and the post must still be there. That is the proof the data is in PostgreSQL and not in the container.
6. **Check the visitor's address once.** Add the variable `LOGGING_LEVEL_NET_ONETECHLY_BRIEF_SECURITY` with the value DEBUG, sign in, and read the log line "Client address ... from header CF-Connecting-IP". Then remove the variable. If the line says the header is missing, tell me what the log shows.
7. **Attach the domain** (Section 7).
8. **Before the validation gate, move to the paid plans** in the second row of the table below. The free database expires 30 days after it is created.

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Which plan, when

Stage	Web service	Database	Per month	Good for
Try it	`free` 512 MB	`free` 256 MB memory, 1 GB storage	$0	M2, for a few days. The service sleeps after 15 minutes without traffic and takes about a minute to wake. **The free database expires 30 days after creation**; after a 14-day grace period it is deleted.
Validation and launch	`0.5c-512mb` $7	`0.1c-256mb` $6	$13	Always on. On a Hobby workspace, the database can be restored to any point in the last 3 days.
Growing	`1c-2g` $25	`0.5c-1g` $19	$44	More memory for the Java process, more connections

Checked on render.com/pricing and Render's documentation on October 9, 2026. The names in code are the plan ids render.yaml uses; version 1 called the two paid web plans Starter and Standard. A Java process on 512 MB is workable for a small board but has little headroom: watch memory in the first week.

What the workspace itself includes

On the Hobby workspace plan ($0)	Included	Beyond that
Custom domains	2	$0.25 per domain per month
Bandwidth	5 GB per month	$0.15 per GB
Build minutes	500 per month	$5 per 1,000
Free web service hours	750 per month for the workspace	Free services are suspended until the next month

These allowances are shared with PixelPerfect if both live in one Hobby workspace. briefmessage.net and www.briefmessage.net are two more custom domains, so expect about $0.50 a month if PixelPerfect already uses the two included ones. Each deploy of a Java service uses a few build minutes. Look at Billing after the first week.

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What render.yaml decides, and how to change it

Line	Meaning	Change it when
`region: virginia`	Where both the service and the database run. It cannot be changed after creation.	Before the first deploy, if your first users are elsewhere (ohio, oregon, frankfurt, singapore)
`postgresMajorVersion: "16"`	The PostgreSQL version the migrations were run on here. Render's default is newer.	Not now. Flyway 10.10 knows PostgreSQL up to 16 and would log a notice on a newer one
`ipAllowList: []`	The database accepts connections from Render's private network only, not from the internet.	If you want to look into the database from your PC with psql: add your address
`plan: free`	Both plans, to try it at no cost.	Before the validation gate (table above)
`autoDeployTrigger: commit`	Every push to the linked branch deploys.	If you prefer to deploy by hand: off

7. Connecting Cloudflare to Render

To your question: yes, this section comes after the Render service is running at its onrender.com address. It is where the "Add record" button of your screenshot is finally used. These are Render's documented steps for a domain whose DNS is at Cloudflare, read again on October 9.

1. **Render:** open the web service, Settings, Custom Domains, and add `briefmessage.net`. Render adds `www.briefmessage.net` as well and redirects it to the main name.
2. **Cloudflare, DNS:** remove any `AAAA` records for the domain if there are any. Render uses IPv4.
3. **Cloudflare, SSL/TLS > Overview:** set the encryption mode to **Full**. Never "Flexible", which sends traffic to the server unencrypted.
4. **Cloudflare, DNS > Records > Add record:** type `CNAME`, name `@`, target `<your-service>.onrender.com`, proxy status **DNS only** (grey cloud). Add a second `CNAME` with name `www`, the same target, also DNS only.
5. **Render:** click Verify next to each domain. Render issues the HTTPS certificate itself and renews it. DNS changes can take a few minutes.
6. Open `https://briefmessage.net`. Register, post, reload. On your phone, the browser now offers to install Brief!.

The MX and TXT records that Email Routing created in M0 stay as they are. A plain `CNAME` at the top of a domain is normally not allowed in DNS; Cloudflare makes it work automatically ("CNAME flattening").

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Grey cloud or orange cloud?

	DNS only (grey)	Proxied (orange)
What Cloudflare does	Answers DNS. Visitors connect straight to Render.	Visitors connect to Cloudflare, which forwards to Render
You gain	Simplicity. Render's own network already includes protection against floods of traffic.	Cloudflare's cache for static files, its firewall rules, one free rate-limiting rule, redirect rules
You must handle	Nothing	The visitor's address now passes through your own Cloudflare zone as well. 2.3.0 already reads CF-Connecting-IP; repeat the DEBUG check of Section 6 after switching.
Recommendation	**Start here.** Render needs it until the certificate is issued anyway.	Optional, later, once the certificates show as issued

After the site is live, under SSL/TLS > Edge Certificates, turn on **Always Use HTTPS**. Leave HSTS off until you are sure HTTPS will never be switched off; it is hard to undo. The application itself deliberately does not send that header (see application.properties).

8. Email

Need	Service	Cost	When
Receive mail at your own domain	Cloudflare Email Routing: forwards to an inbox you already have. It adds its own MX, SPF and DKIM records.	Free	**NOW** M0, Section 4
Send verification links, password resets, mention alerts	A transactional email provider, called from the application over HTTPS. Examples and their free allowances as checked on October 6: Resend (3,000 a month, 100 a day), Brevo (300 a day), Postmark (100 a month), Amazon SES (pay per message).	$0 to start	**LATER** M3

- Sending from your own domain needs three DNS records, which the provider gives you: **SPF** (who may send), **DKIM** (a signature) and **DMARC** (what receivers should do with mail that fails). A domain can have only one SPF record, so the provider's entry is merged with the one Email Routing created.
- Use the provider's HTTPS API, not SMTP. Render's free instances block the SMTP ports.
- **One decision M3 needs from you:** which provider. It takes an account in your name and those DNS records, so it cannot be prepared without you.

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9. New Features: Attachments and the Installable App

Attachments: your proposal, assessed

> **Verdict**
>
> **Yes. Attachments belong in Brief!.** "The report is attached" is exactly the kind of post a 255-character board is for, and a screenshot often says what a short text cannot. Build them after private boards (M4), starting with images, PDF and text files. Treat video separately.

Your screenshot of the phone's message app shows what opens behind the + button. Not all of it suits a team board:

In the phone's menu	For Brief!	Why
Gallery, Camera	**YES** first	A screenshot or a photo of a whiteboard is the most common thing a team adds to a short update. On a phone, the same button offers the camera.
Files (PDF, text, documents)	**YES** first	"Minutes of today's meeting attached."
Video	**LATER** and small	Large to store and to send, and a video must be converted before it plays on every device. Start by letting a post link to where the video already is; allow short clips once storage costs are known.
GIFs, Stickers	No	Chat features. They work against "every post gets read".
Location, Contacts	No	Not what a team board is for.
Schedule send	Worth considering	"Post this on Monday at 9" suits planned team updates. It is not an attachment: it needs a timer on the server and no storage. A candidate for after M4.

Why after private boards, and not now

- **Who can open the file.** Today everyone who registers sees every post. A file on such a board is public. On a private board it is a team's own business, and the rule "only members of this board may download it" has something to check against.
- **Legal exposure.** Hosting strangers' files is where copyright complaints and worse begin (Section 13). A private, invited group changes that picture.
- **Where the file lives.** Inside a container, a file is erased at every deploy. Attachments need storage outside the application, which only makes sense once the application is hosted (M2).
- **Building it once.** Every file will belong to a workspace. Written before workspaces exist, the feature would have to be rewritten in M4.

How it would be built

Piece	Choice	Why
Where files live	Object storage: Cloudflare R2	It speaks the same protocol as Amazon S3, so standard Java libraries work. First 10 GB stored are free each month, then $0.015 per GB per month, and downloads are not charged.

Piece	Choice	Why
Upload	The browser asks the server for a one-time upload address and sends the file straight to storage	Large files never pass through the 512 MB Java process
Database	A new table: one row per file, with its post, its board, name, type, size and storage key. A new migration, V3 or later	The post itself stays 255 characters; the file is beside it
Download	The server checks board membership, then hands out an address that works for a few minutes	Private files stay private. No public bucket
Limits	10 MB per file; up to 4 files per post; images, PDF and plain text; the type is checked from the content, not the name	Predictable cost; a renamed program is refused
On screen	Images as a thumbnail that opens larger; other files as a named chip with their size; a + button beside Post, as in your screenshot	The post text stays the main thing
Safety	User files that a browser could run (HTML, SVG) are offered as downloads, never displayed inside the site	A file must not be able to act as a page of briefmessage.net

R2 prices from developers.cloudflare.com/r2/pricing, October 9, 2026. Effort: one to two weeks after M4. Pricing effects: Section 11.

The installable app: what 2.3.0 has

Capability	State	Notes
Install from the browser	**BUILT**	Android and desktop Chrome or Edge: the line "Install Brief! on this device". iPhone and iPad: Share, then Add to Home Screen; the app says so.
Own window and icon	**BUILT**	No address bar. The icon is the green square with the white bar.
Opens without a connection	**BUILT**	The app's own files are kept on the device; the screen says "You're offline". Posts are never stored on the device.
Unread count on the icon	**BUILT**	Where the system supports it, and while the app is running.
Stay signed in	**BUILT**	Ticked by default in the installed app. Lasts until sign-out or 12 hours, whichever comes first. Longer with M3.
Notification while the app is closed	**LATER**	M3. See below.

- **It needs HTTPS**, so on a phone it works from the day M2 is online. On the computer it works now at http://localhost:8080.
- **No app store**, no store fee, no review. An update reaches every installed copy at the next deploy.
- **It is not a native app.** It will not appear in the App Store or Google Play. For a team tool that people are invited to by a link, that is rarely a loss.

Next for the app: notifications that reach a closed app (M3)

This is your original idea for mentions: the member notices even while away, working or in a meeting. The browser standard for it is Web Push. The server sends a small message through the phone maker's push service, and the service worker that 2.3.0 installed shows it. It works on Android and on desktop browsers. On iPhone and iPad it works from iOS 16.4, only for a site that was added to the Home Screen, and only after the member allows it with a tap inside that installed app. The manifest shipped in 2.3.0 already meets those conditions. It belongs with M3 because a notification is tied to an account on a device, and M3 is where accounts become real.

10. Stripe

> **Your question: implement Stripe in this cycle, or wait?**
>
> **Wait.** Not because it is hard; PixelPerfect already taught you the three parts. Because there is nothing to charge for yet.
>
> What Brief! sells is a board. Until M4 there is one public board, so a subscription has nothing to attach to. Stripe also expects the public site to show a price, a refund and cancellation policy, a privacy policy and a support contact before live payments, and those pages are planned for M3. And the validation gate sits before M5 on purpose: if two of five teams would pay, build it; if none would, you have saved those weeks.
>
> What costs nothing and can be done any time: create a separate Stripe account for Brief! under your existing login, in sandbox mode, so its name and reports stay apart from PixelPerfect's.

The design from version 1 is unchanged, and is repeated here so this document stands on its own. Three parts: **Checkout** (Stripe's hosted payment page), the **customer portal** (Stripe's hosted "manage my subscription" page) and **webhooks** (Stripe telling your server what happened). Card numbers never touch your server.

Step	What happens	Your code
1	The board's owner clicks Upgrade	The server creates a Checkout Session in subscription mode for that workspace and returns its URL
2	Stripe's page takes the card	None
3	Stripe calls your webhook: `checkout.session.completed`	Store the Stripe customer id and subscription id on the workspace
4	Stripe calls: `invoice.paid`	Mark the workspace as on the paid plan until the end of the period. **This event, not the browser's return, unlocks the plan.**
5	Each month: `invoice.paid` again, or `invoice.payment_failed`	Extend, or warn the owner
6	The owner opens "Manage billing"	The server creates a customer portal session and redirects there
7	Stripe calls: `customer.subscription.updated` or `.deleted`	When the status becomes canceled or unpaid, return the workspace to the free plan

- **Verify every webhook call** against the endpoint's signing secret, using the raw request body (`Webhook.constructEvent` in com.stripe:stripe-java). An unverified webhook lets anyone grant themselves the paid plan.
- **Expect duplicates and wrong order.** Keep a table of processed event ids; act on the state inside the event.

- **Answer 200 quickly**, then do the work. The route needs no login; the signature is its authentication.
- **Secrets live in Render's environment**, never in the repository. Test and live keys differ, and so do their webhook secrets.

Fees for a United States account as checked on October 6, 2026: 2.9% + 30 cents per successful domestic card charge; Stripe Billing adds 0.7% of subscription volume on the pay-as-you-go plan; Stripe Tax, if used, 0.5% per transaction where you are registered. The customer portal is included.

11. Pricing Model

A price is a guess until someone pays it. You asked whether attachments should change the plans. My view: they should change what is *in* the plans, not the price.

Proposed starting model: flat price per board, now with files

Plan	Price	Includes	Files (from M4a)	Purpose
Free	$0	One board, up to 5 members, the last 90 days of posts	Images only, 100 MB for the board	Lets a team start in a minute and feel the habit. The member limit, not a time limit, prompts the upgrade.
Team	**$12 a month per board**, or $120 a year	Up to 25 members, full history, mention alerts by email and push, export of posts	Images, PDF and text; 10 MB per file; 5 GB for the board	The plan most paying customers would be on
Larger	Later, on request	More members, single sign-on, audit log	More storage, video	Build only when someone asks

Why keep $12 when files are added	Why give files a limit at all
Storage is cheap. A Team board that fills its 5 GB costs about 8 cents a month at R2's list price ($0.015 a GB), and the first 10 GB across all boards are free.	The limit protects against misuse more than against cost: without one, a board becomes somebody's backup drive.
Nobody has paid $12 yet. Changing the number now replaces one guess with another. The validation gate is where it gets tested.	It also makes the difference between Free and Team something a team can feel: more people, all the history, real files.

What comparable tools charge

Product	Paid plan	List price	Unit	A team of 10 pays, per month
Slack	Pro	$8.75 monthly, $7.25 billed annually	per user	$87.50
Zulip Cloud	Standard	$8 monthly, $6.67 billed annually	per user	$80
Range	Pro	$8	per user	$80
Twist	Unlimited	$6	per user	$60
Microsoft Teams Essentials	-	$4, billed annually	per user	$40

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Product	Paid plan	List price	Unit	A team of 10 pays, per month
Geekbot (stand-up bot)	Basic	$3 monthly, $2.50 billed annually	per participant	$30
Basecamp	Freelancer	$25	flat	$25

Public list prices as checked on the vendors' own pages on October 6, 2026 (not rechecked for this version). These tools do far more than Brief!. They are shown to locate the ceiling, not to claim equivalence.

What one paying board is worth

Per paying board, per month	Amount
Price	$12.00
Card fee: 2.9% + $0.30	- $0.65
Stripe Billing: 0.7%	- $0.08
Left before tax, hosting and storage	**$11.27**
Fixed hosting at launch (Section 12)	$13 a month, whatever the number of boards
Paying boards needed to cover hosting	**2**

Read with care

These figures are arithmetic on list prices, not a forecast of income. They leave out sales tax (Section 13), refunds, disputes and your time. A free plan also has a cost: every free board uses the same server.

12. Monthly Cost at Each Stage

Item	M0 to M2 trial	Validation and launch	Growing
Domain (briefmessage.net)	Paid for the year; see your Cloudflare invoice	same	same
Cloudflare DNS, HTTPS certificate, email routing	$0	$0	$0
Render web service	$0 (sleeps when idle)	$7	$25
Render Postgres	$0 (expires after 30 days)	$6	$19
Extra custom domains on Render	up to $0.50 if the workspace's two included domains are in use	same	same
Transactional email (from M3)	-	$0 within the free allowance	about $15 to $20
File storage on R2 (from M4a)	-	$0 within the first 10 GB	$0.015 per GB beyond 10 GB

Item	M0 to M2 trial	Validation and launch	Growing
Stripe (from M5)	-	A share of each payment only	A share of each payment only
Fixed total per month	**$0**, or $0.50	**$13**, or $13.50	**about $60**

One-time: registering a DMCA agent with the United States Copyright Office costs $6 and is renewed every three years. Section 13 explains what that is.

13. Legal and Compliance Checklist

A checklist of what a United States product with accounts and user-written content normally has at launch, with where to read more. **I am not a lawyer or a tax adviser.** Use this to prepare the conversation with one, not to replace it.

> **On timing: the policy pages can wait a little, as you suggested**
>
> Agreed. Terms, Privacy and the refund and cancellation policy describe what the product does with people's data and money, so they are easier to write once that is settled. They are needed at two points: Terms and Privacy before strangers can register (M3), and the refund and cancellation policy before a live payment (M5). Until then the people using Brief! are you and teams you invited.

Item	What it is	Needed by	Where to start
Terms of Service	The contract with users: acceptable use, what happens to content, how accounts end. State a minimum age of 13.	M3	A lawyer, or a reputable template adapted to what Brief! really does
Privacy Policy	What you collect (username, email, posts, later files, IP address in logs), why, who processes it (Render, Cloudflare, Stripe, the email provider), and how to delete it	M3	Required by Stripe before live payments
Refund and cancellation policy	When a customer can cancel and whether anything is refunded	M5	Stripe's "website checklist" page, on docs.stripe.com
Children (COPPA)	The law covers services directed at children under 13, or that knowingly collect their data. A work tool that states 13+ is the usual approach.	M3	ftc.gov, COPPA frequently asked questions
Copyright complaints (DMCA)	A named contact for copyright complaints, registered with the Copyright Office. Explained below.	M6, and before attachments are open to strangers	copyright.gov/dmca-directory
Files from users (new)	With attachments, the host has to be able to remove a file quickly and to say how to report one. Some kinds of illegal material carry duties of their own.	Before M4a	Ask the lawyer who reviews the Terms what a host must do when illegal material is reported
New York sales tax	New York treats software accessed over the internet as taxable when sold to customers in New York.	M5	tax.ny.gov, bulletin TB-ST-128. Stripe Tax can calculate it. Confirm with an accountant.

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Item	What it is	Needed by	Where to start
Other states and countries	Rules differ and have thresholds. Most do not apply to a product with a handful of customers.	After M5	An accountant; Stripe Tax's monitoring
Email (CAN-SPAM)	Marketing email needs a postal address and a working unsubscribe. Password resets and receipts are treated differently.	M3	ftc.gov, CAN-SPAM compliance guide
European users (GDPR)	Applies if you offer the service to people in the EU, not merely because the site can be opened there.	Before marketing there	Decide whether to market there before worrying
The business	OneTechly, LLC already exists and can own Brief!, as it owns PixelPerfect.	-	Your accountant, for how to keep the products' books apart
The name	"Brief" is a common word in software.	Before paying for a logo or advertising	Search the USPTO trademark database

What the DMCA line means

You asked what "registering a DMCA agent costs $6 and is renewed every three years" really means. In plain terms:

- **The problem.** On Brief! people post text, and later files. If one of them posts something that belongs to somebody else, for example a paid report or a photo, the owner could hold the site responsible.
- **The protection.** A United States law, the Digital Millennium Copyright Act, says a site that only stores what its users post is not liable for their copyright infringement, provided it follows a procedure. That protection is called the "safe harbor" (section 512 of the Copyright Act). It is not automatic.
- **The procedure has four parts:** name a contact who receives copyright complaints, the "designated agent", and register that contact in the Copyright Office's online directory; publish the same contact on the site; remove the material promptly when a proper complaint arrives; and have, and apply, a rule that closes the accounts of people who do it repeatedly.
- **The $6.** The Copyright Office charges $6 for each designation, amendment or resubmission. A designation expires three years after it is registered unless it is renewed, and renewing means submitting it again for $6. The agent can be a person, a job title, a department or an outside firm; one per service provider. Here the service provider would be OneTechly, LLC, and the contact could be the support address created in M0.
- **When.** It costs little and takes minutes, so before public launch (M6) at the latest. It matters more once attachments exist.

Fee and renewal period from the Copyright Office's own questions-and-answers page, copyright.gov/dmca-directory/faq.html, read on October 9, 2026. Whether and how the safe harbor applies to your service is a question for a lawyer.

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14. Scaling: What Breaks Next, and the Fix

Version 1 listed nine things that break as Brief! grows. 2.3.0 does three of them and half of a fourth (usernames), and one that version 1 missed: the login limit behind a proxy. The table shows those first, then what remains in the order it will be needed:

Today	Becomes a problem when	Step	State
H2 file database; schema changed by Hibernate at start-up	The first deployment	PostgreSQL; Flyway migrations; foreign keys	**DONE** 2.3.0
Usernames differing only in capitals	Two members with "the same" name	A unique lower-case key	**DONE** 2.3.0
Mentions endpoint returns everything	A member mentioned thousands of times	Paged like the feed	**DONE** 2.3.0
Static files marked "do not cache"	Visitors far from the server, or many of them	/assets cached for a year. Later: proxy through Cloudflare	**DONE** 2.3.0
The login limit counted the proxy, not the visitor	The first deployment	Read the proxy's header; count IPv6 by block	**DONE** 2.3.0
Mention look-up compares the post with every username	Tens of thousands of members	Count only names written with @, looked up by index	**LATER**
Every browser asks every 15 seconds	Hundreds of people online at once	Server-Sent Events: the server pushes new posts down one open connection	After M4
Rate-limit counts and signed-out tokens in one server's memory	A second server instance, or the wish to keep them across restarts	Render Key Value (Redis-compatible), or shorter-lived tokens	When a second instance is needed
One instance	Memory or processor is the limit, or zero-downtime deploys matter	A larger instance first. Then two instances, which the step above makes possible	When measured
One public board	The first team that wants privacy	A workspace id on every row and in every query	M4
Files have nowhere to live (new)	The first attachment	Object storage outside the application (R2)	M4a
Alerts need the app to be open (new)	A member who is away from the screen	Web Push through the service worker 2.3.0 installed	M3
Console logs only	The first problem you cannot reproduce	Structured logs, an uptime check, error alerts. 2.3.0 adds one start-up line naming the database	M6

The order matters more than the list. Each step is taken when a measurement or a customer asks for it, not before. Brief! on one small instance with PostgreSQL will serve its first hundred teams.

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15. This Week

#	From version 1	State
1	The Levrx take-home task	DONE
2	Run Brief! 2.2.0's tests and send the result	DONE 149 of 149
3	M0: auto-renew, DNSSEC, two-factor sign-in, the two forwarding addresses	YOU Section 4 walks through it
4a	Is direction B the product?	DONE Yes
4b	Should 2.3 be the deployable build?	DONE Yes; it is this release

Now, in this order:

1. **Run the 2.3.0 tests** and send the line: `Tests run: 207, Failures: 0, Errors: 0, Skipped: 0`. Everything else builds on it.
2. **M0, 30 minutes:** click Activate on the Email Routing page, add the destination address and the two rules, enable DNSSEC, turn on two-factor sign-in, confirm auto-renew.
3. **Push 2.3.0 to GitHub** and watch the five CI jobs.
4. **M2:** Render, New > Blueprint. Then Section 7 for the domain. Send a screenshot of the first log lines.
5. **Tell me two things for the next release (2.4, real accounts):** which email provider you want to send from, and whether you want the study copy of 2.3.0. For the study copy I need the 2.2.0 study zip, which was not part of this session.

> **Bottom line**
>
> The request as a whole is realistic, and most of it is now done or decided: the links, the installable app, the deployable build, the Cloudflare and Render steps. What I changed is the size of the step. One milestone per release, each verified on your machine before the next, is what has kept every first run clean so far.
>
> Nothing in this plan needs money before the validation gate, and the gate needs about $13 a month. The expensive part is still your time.

Sources checked for this version

- Render: render.com/pricing; render.com/docs/blueprint-spec; render.com/docs/web-services; render.com/docs/custom-domains; render.com/docs/configure-cloudflare-dns; render.com/articles/platforms-with-a-real-free-tier-for-developers-in-2026 (free tier limits). October 9, 2026.
- Cloudflare: developers.cloudflare.com/email-service/configuration/email-routing-addresses; developers.cloudflare.com/dns/dnssec; developers.cloudflare.com/r2/pricing. October 9, 2026.
- United States Copyright Office: copyright.gov/dmca-directory/faq.html. October 9, 2026.
- Installing web apps: developer.chrome.com/blog/update-install-criteria. Push on iPhone and iPad: documentation.onesignal.com/docs/web-push-for-ios. October 9, 2026.
- The visitor's address on Render (CF-Connecting-IP, True-Client-IP) comes from other Render users' published reports, not from Render's documentation, which is why Section 6 has you check it once.
- Stripe fees, email providers' allowances and competitors' prices: as checked for version 1 on October 6, 2026.

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